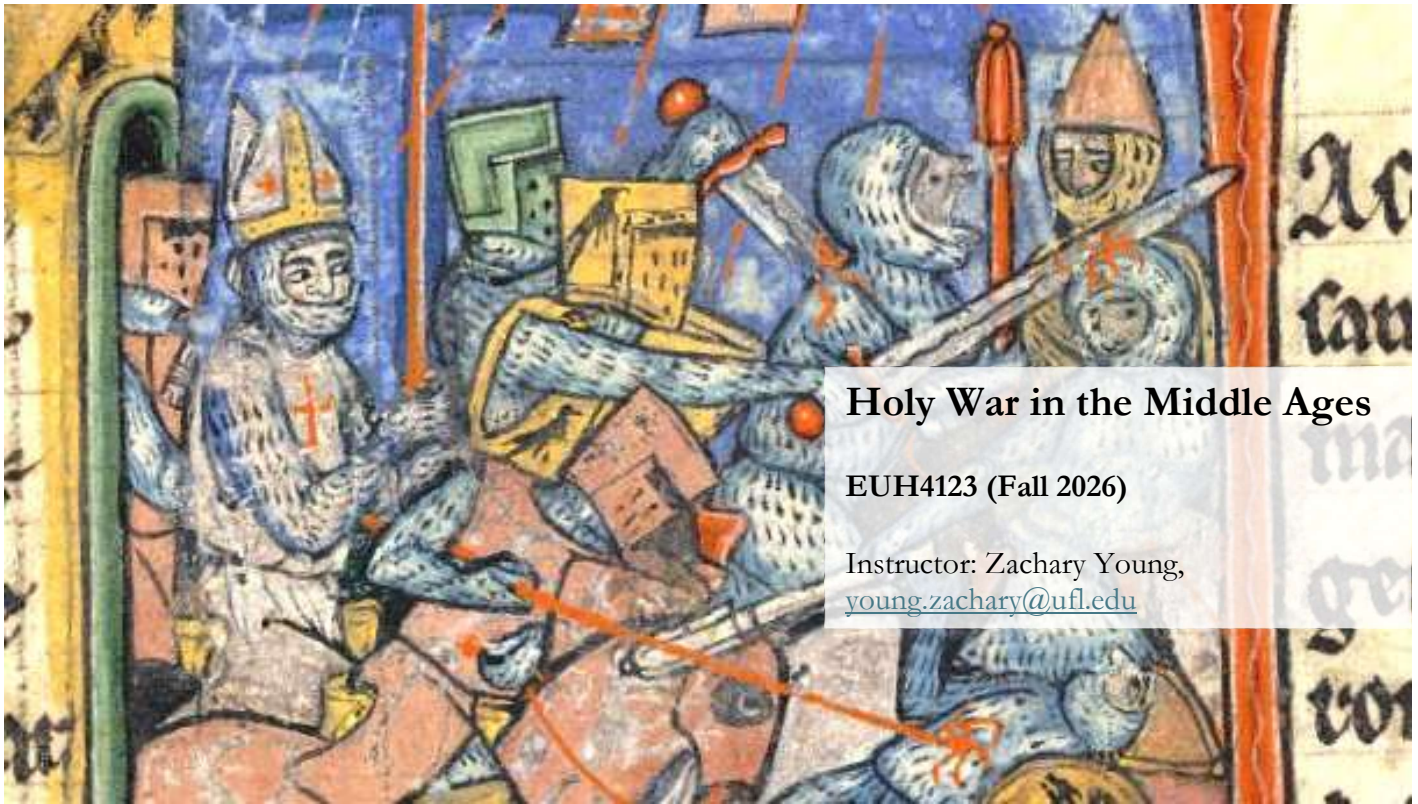




Holy War in the Middle Ages

EUH4123 (Fall 2026)

Instructor: Zachary Young,
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"I pray and exhort, nay not I, but the Lord prays and exhorts you, as heralds of Christ...to hasten to exterminate this vile race from the lands of our brethren." (Pope Urban I, November 26, 1095)

"Jesus, King of Peace, who rejects war, whom no one can use to justify war. He does not listen to the prayers of those who wage war." (Pope Leo XIV, March 29, 2026)

Course Description: Although pacifistic interpretations of Jesus and of Christianity have become increasingly popular in recent years, Christianity also has a long history of sacralized violence. This course uses the example of the Crusades to engage the continual tension in Christian history between violence and nonviolence.

Course Meets: Tuesdays, 8:30-10:25am, and Thursdays, 9:35-10:25am, in Keene-Flint 0119 (3 credits)

Instructor Contact Information: I am accessible and responsive to any student needs, concerns, or questions. You can reach me by email at young.zachary@ufl.edu. I will hold office hours on Thursdays at 8:30-9:20am in Keene-Flint 207; if you would like to arrange a meeting at a different time, please email me or talk to me after class.

Course Objectives: Students in this class will develop their knowledge and skills in terms of:

- Understanding the theological tensions between sacralized violence and religious nonviolence;
- Reading primary sources and engaging with their perspectives;
- Learning how to ask good questions;
- Conducting independent research; and
- Thinking with history and historicizing contemporary practices.

Grading and Assignments: My grading rubric for this course is as follows.

Attendance (30%). I will take attendance in class! I will drop one absence. To be excused, subsequent absences require a doctor's note. Please make every effort to be on time to class.

Written Assignments (70%). There is one written assignment corresponding to each of the four units of the course. Each assignment is weighted equally as 17.5% of your final grade.

Assignment 1. Analysis of Biblical and Patristic Foundations of Sacred Violence (Due 9/15)

This paper asks you to reflect on the ways that sacred violence is reflected and understood in contemporary religion. You have three options for completing this assignment:

- 1) **Historiography.** Find three modern scholars who have commented on the way that the Biblical/patristic texts on sacred violence should be applied within modern Christianity (or Judaism, or Islam). Write a 500-word historiographical paper assessing these different schools of thought.
- 2) **Anthropology.** Interview three of your friends (or church leaders, or etc.) and ask them what they think about Biblical/patristic sources on violence. How should religious people today look at these texts? What do they mean for us today? Write a 500-word paper describing and analyzing their opinions. Don't include any identifying information for your friends.
- 3) **Theology.** What do you think these passages should mean for Christianity (or Judaism, or Islam) in the modern context? 500 words.

Assignment 2. First Religious Service Observation (Due 10/13)

This paper asks you to visit a religious service (Christian, Jewish, or Islamic) and look for ways that the story of the Crusades and sacred violence is (or is not) reflected in the service. To complete this assignment:

- 1) Attend a religious service. You may attend the service with friends from the class. Be sure to take a selfie or gather other proof of attendance.
- 2) Think about different elements in the service that reflect (or could potentially reflect) the history of the Crusades and sacred violence. You can discuss this part of the assignment with friends.
- 3) Write 500 words explaining your observations from the service and how the history of sacred violence is (or is not) reflected in contemporary religious practice.

Assignment 3. Second Religious Service Observation (Due 11/3)

This paper asks you to visit a religious service (Christian, Jewish, or Islamic) and look for ways that the story of sacred violence is (or is not) reflected in the service. To complete this assignment:

- 1) Attend a religious service. You may attend the service with friends from the class. Be sure to take a selfie or gather other proof of attendance. The service should be of a different denomination (i.e. not both Catholic, or both Presbyterian) than the first service that you attended.
- 2) Think about different elements in the service that reflect (or could potentially reflect) the history of the Crusades and sacred violence. You can discuss this part of the assignment with friends.
- 3) Write 500 words explaining your observations from the service and how the history of sacred violence is (or is not) reflected in contemporary religious practice.

Assignment 4. Analysis of Modern Uses of Crusading Rhetoric (Due 12/1)

This paper asks you to reflect on the ways that sacred violence is reflected and understood in contemporary religion. You have three options for completing this assignment:

- 1) Historiography. Find three modern scholars who have commented on the way that sacred violence is discussed in modern Christianity (or Judaism, or Islam). Write a 500-word historiographical paper assessing these different schools of thought.
- 2) Anthropology. Interview three of your friends (or church leaders, or etc.) and ask them what they think the role of sacred violence is. How should religious people today look at these texts? What do they mean for us today? Write a 500-word paper describing and analyzing their opinions. Don't include any identifying information for your friends.
- 3) Theology. What is the role of sacred violence in Christianity (or Judaism, or Islam) in the modern context? 500 words.

A course grade > 93% will earn an A. A course grade between 90% and 93% will earn an A-. Between 87% and 90% will earn a B+. Between 83% and 87% will earn a B, and so on. Here are the current UF grading policies for converting grades into grade points: <https://catalog.ufl.edu/UGRD/academic-regulations/grades-grading-policies/#gradestext>

Course Materials: There are no required readings. Instead of assigning secondary sources, I have prepared primary sources for us to discuss together in class.

Schedule for Readings and Discussions: See the following table. We will read each day's readings together in class.

Unit I. Biblical and Patristic Foundations of Sacred Violence

Date	Topic	Guiding Question	Primary Sources
Thursday 8/20 (Week 0)	Syllabus Review	<i>What is holy war? Can violence ever be sacred?</i>	
Tuesday 8/25 (Week 1)	Violence in the Hebrew Bible	<i>What was the role of violence in the Hebrew Bible? How are passages about violence in the Hebrew Bible understood today?</i>	Deuteronomy 20:1-20 Joshua 6:1-27 Psalm 83:1-18; 63:10-11; 137:7-9 1 Samuel 15:1-35 1 Maccabees 2:1-70
Thursday 8/27 (Week 1)	Violence in the New Testament	<i>How does the NT characterize violence? What are continuities/tensions between the NT and the HB?</i>	Isaiah 2:1-5 Matthew 5:9, 17-22, 38-48; also 10:34-36; 26:47-56 Luke 3:14 Romans 13:1-7 Ephesians 6:10-17
Tuesday 9/1 (Week 2)	Early Christian Military Service	<i>How did Christians understand/justify military service?</i>	1 Clement 37 Eusebius, <i>Life of Constantine</i>, book 1, ch. 26-29; 46 Sulpicius Severus, <i>Life of Martin</i>, ch. 2-4 Augustine, <i>Letter 189</i>, 4-6

			<u>Athanasius, Letter 48</u>
Thursday 9/3 (Week 2)	Early Christian Pacificism	<i>Which Christians objected to violence and why?</i>	<u>Justin Martyr, First Apology, ch. 39</u> <u>Tertullian, On Idolatry, 19</u> <u>Origen, Against Celsus, book 8, ch. 73-75</u> <u>Story of St. Telemachus</u>
Tuesday 9/8 (Week 3)	Augustinianism and Just War Theory	<i>How were Christian approaches to violence influenced by developing (late antique) political realities?</i>	<u>Catechism of the Catholic Church 2302-2311</u> <u>Augustine, Contra Faustum, book 22, 70-79</u> <u>Augustine, City of God, book 19, ch. 7</u>
Thursday 9/10 (Week 3)	Recent criticism of Just War Theory	<i>How were Christian approaches to violence influenced by developing (20th century) political realities?</i>	<u>Gaudium et Spes 79-82</u> <u>Angelus address by Pope Francis (1/14/2024)</u> <u>Homily by Pope Leo XIV (3/29/2026)</u> <u>Bishop James Massa on Just War Theory (04/15/2026)</u> First Assignment due before next class (9/15)

Unit II. The Crusades

Date	Topic	Guiding Question	Primary Sources
Tuesday 9/15 (Week 4)	Christian Opposition to Islam	<i>On what grounds did Christians begin to consider Muslims as the enemy?</i>	<u>John of Damascus on Islam</u> <u>Eulogius of Cordoba, Apology for the Martyrs</u>

			<u>Accounts of the Battle of Tours</u>
Thursday 9/17 (Week 4)	Christian Irenicism towards Islam	<i>What were non-militarized perspectives on how to approach Islam?</i>	<u>Gregory VII, Letter to Anziri (1076): PL 148, pg. 450 (translation to be provided in class)</u> Pablo de Santa Maria, <i>Additiones</i> on Exodus 8 and on Revelation 13 (translation to be distributed in class) <u>Nostra Aetate 3</u> Arabic Mass texts (to be distributed in class)
Tuesday 9/22 (Week 5)	The Council of Clermont and the Call to Crusade	<i>What motivated the use of sacred violence in the form of the Crusades?</i>	<u>Clermont Speech</u> <u>First Crusade Chronicle</u>
Thursday 9/24 (Week 5)	Responses to Crusading Violence	<i>How did the violence unleashed in the Crusades affect European society?</i>	<u>Rhineland martyrdom accounts</u> <u>Kina 25</u>
Tuesday 9/29 (Week 6)	Jerusalem in the Crusades	<i>How did Crusaders understand the city of Jerusalem?</i>	<u>Jerusalem in liturgy</u> Jerusalem in art (to be provided in class) <u>Bernard of Clairvaux on the Templars</u> <u>Capture of Jerusalem by Saladin</u>
Thursday 10/1 (Week 6)	Spiritualizing Jerusalem	<i>Could Jerusalem mean something other than the city in Judea?</i>	<u>Bernard of Clairvaux, Letter XIV</u> Jerusalem in the psalms and in Christian liturgy
Tuesday 10/6 (Week 7)	The Failure of the Crusades	<i>How did Crusaders interpret failure?</i>	<u>Fall of Constantinople</u> <u>Pope Innocent's Complaint about the Fall of Constantinople</u> <u>Fall of Acre</u>

Thursday 10/8 (Week 7)	Crusading Elsewhere in Europe	<i>What were the lasting political implications of the Crusades?</i>	The Latin Chronicle of the Kings of Castile Second Assignment due before next class (10/13)
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Unit III. The Expansion of Sacred Violence

Date	Topic	Guiding Question	Primary Sources
Tuesday 10/13 (Week 8)	Heresy	<i>What is heresy? How were heretics to be treated?</i> <i>How does violence against heresy compare to the violence of the crusades?</i>	Fourth Lateran Council, Canon 3: On Heresy Aquinas, Summa Theologiae, secunda secundae, q. 11 art. 3 Caesarius of Heisterbach, Dialogue on Miracles, ch. 20-22 Letter Establishing the Spanish Inquisition
Thursday 10/15 (Week 8)	Opposition to the burning of heretics	<i>Who opposed the burning of heretics and why?</i>	Erasmus, In Praise of Folly, pp. 47-48 Leo X, Exsurge Domine, 33-34 (against propositions of Luther) Pope John Paul II apology on the burning of Hus
Tuesday 10/20 (Week 9)	Clerical violence; degradation and the Death Penalty	<i>Who was liable to the death penalty? How was the death penalty understood as enacting justice?</i> <i>Who opposed the death penalty? How did opponents of the death penalty reconcile the earlier history of its use?</i>	Augustine, City of God, Book I ch. 21 Aquinas, Summa Theologiae, secunda secundae q. 64 Catechism of the Council of Trent, pp. 124, 177-178 Pope Francis's revision of CCC 2267

			<u>Pope Leo XIV on the death penalty</u>
Thursday 10/22 (Week 9)	Violence done by, and to, clerics	<i>How were clerics implicated in violence?</i>	<u>Lateran IV, can. 18</u> <u>1917 Code of Canon Law, can. 138</u> <u>1983 Code of Canon Law, can. 1370</u> <u>Rite of Degradation</u>
Tuesday 10/27 (Week 10)	Anti-Jewish Violence	<i>Why did Christians use physical violence against Jews?</i>	<u>Lateran IV on the Jews</u> <u>The Life and Miracles of St. William of Norwich</u> <u>The Ritual Murder Accusation at Blois</u> <u>Ferran Martinez's Speech (1388)</u>
Thursday 10/29 (Week 10)	The Legacy of Anti-Jewish Violence	<i>How did later Christians understand anti-Jewish violence?</i>	Pablo de Santa Maria on the events of 1391 (to be distributed) <u>Nostra Aetate 4</u> <u>Memory and Reconciliation: The Church and the Faults of the Past 5.4</u> Third Assignment due 11/3

Unit IV. Modern Afterlives of Medieval Holy War

Date	Topic	Guiding Question	Primary Sources
Tuesday 11/3 (Week 11)	Holy War in the Early Modern: The Continuation of the Crusades	<i>To what extent were early modern wars likened to Crusades?</i>	<u>Christopher Columbus on Jerusalem (excerpts)</u> <u>Cisneros on Jerusalem (excerpts)</u> Early modern art of Lepanto and Santiago Mataindios (to be distributed)

			<i>The Last Crusade</i> (excerpts)
Thursday 11/5 (Week 11)	Modern Crusading Rhetoric	<i>What is crusading rhetoric useful for?</i>	<u>Ronald Reagan on the Ash Heap of History</u> <u>George W. Bush on Crusading</u> <u>Barack Obama on Crusading</u> <u>Paula White on Trump as a Crusader</u>
Tuesday 11/10 (Week 12)	Jihad	<i>Does modern rhetoric of jihad draw upon crusade?</i>	<u>At-Tawbah 9:5</u> <u>Al-Baqarah 2:216</u> <u>An-Nisa 4:74</u> <u>Sayyid Qutb, <i>Milestones</i>, ch. 4</u> <u>Fatwa by Osama bin Laden</u>
Thursday 11/12 (Week 12)	Sanctification of Military Force	<i>To what extent do modern claims of military sanctity rely on the crusades?</i>	<u>Cathedral of the Russian Armed Forces</u> <u>Russian clergy blessing ICBMs</u> <u>“Weapons in the Hand of God” (Adamsky book review)</u> <u>Interview of George Zabelka with Charles McCarthy</u> <u>Cardinal O’Connor on Military Chaplains, 7</u> <u><i>Pacem in Terra</i>, 112-113</u> <u><i>Good Defeats Evil</i></u>
Tuesday 11/17 (Week 13)	Interpreting the State of Israel	<i>How are ideas of sacred violence used by</i>	<u>Article on John Hagee</u>

		<i>interpreters of the State of Israel?</i>	“The Rise of Itamar Ben-Gvir” “Israeli Ministers Attend Conference”
Thursday 11/19 (Week 13)	Interpreting current events	<i>Is the US currently fighting any holy wars?</i>	Pete Hegseth’s Pentagon speech (03/25/2026) Pete Hegseth’s political views Topical primary sources corresponding to current events Fourth Assignment due 12/1
Tuesday 12/1 (Week 14)	Conclusions		

Course Disclaimer: Requirements for class attendance and make-up exams, assignments, and other work in the course are consistent with university policies. See UF Academic Regulations and Policies for more information regarding the University Attendance Policies.

For students with disabilities: Students with disabilities who experience learning barriers and would like to request academic accommodations should connect with the Disability Resource Center. See the “Get Started With the DRC” webpage on the Disability Resource Center site. It is important for students to share their accommodation letter with their instructor and discuss their access needs, as early as possible in the semester.

Course Evaluations: Students are expected to provide professional and respectful feedback on the quality of instruction in this course by completing course evaluations online. Students can complete evaluations in three ways: 1. The email they receive from GatorEvals, 2. Their Canvas course menu under GatorEvals, or 3. The central portal at <https://my-ufl.bluer.com>. Guidance on how to provide constructive feedback is available at <https://gatorevals.ua.ufl.edu/students/>. Students will be notified when the evaluation period opens. Summaries of course evaluation results are available to students at <https://gatorevals.ua.ufl.edu/public-results/>.

Campus Resources: U Matter, We Care: If you or someone you know is in distress, please contact umatter@ufl.edu, 352-392-1575, or visit U Matter, We Care website to refer or report a concern and a team member will reach out to the student in distress. Counseling and Wellness Center: Visit the Counseling and Wellness Center website or call 352-392-1575 for information on crisis services as well as non-crisis services. Student Health Care Center: Call 352-392-1161 for 24/7 information to help you find the care you need, or visit the Student Health Care Center website. University Police Department: Visit UF Police Department website or call 352-392-1111 (or 9-1-1 for emergencies). UF Health Shands Emergency Room / Trauma Center: For immediate medical care call 352-733-0111 or go to the emergency room at 1515 SW Archer Road, Gainesville, FL 32608; Visit the UF Health Emergency Room and Trauma Center website. GatorWell Health Promotion Services: For prevention services focused on optimal wellbeing, including Wellness Coaching for Academic Success, visit the GatorWell website or call 352-273-4450.